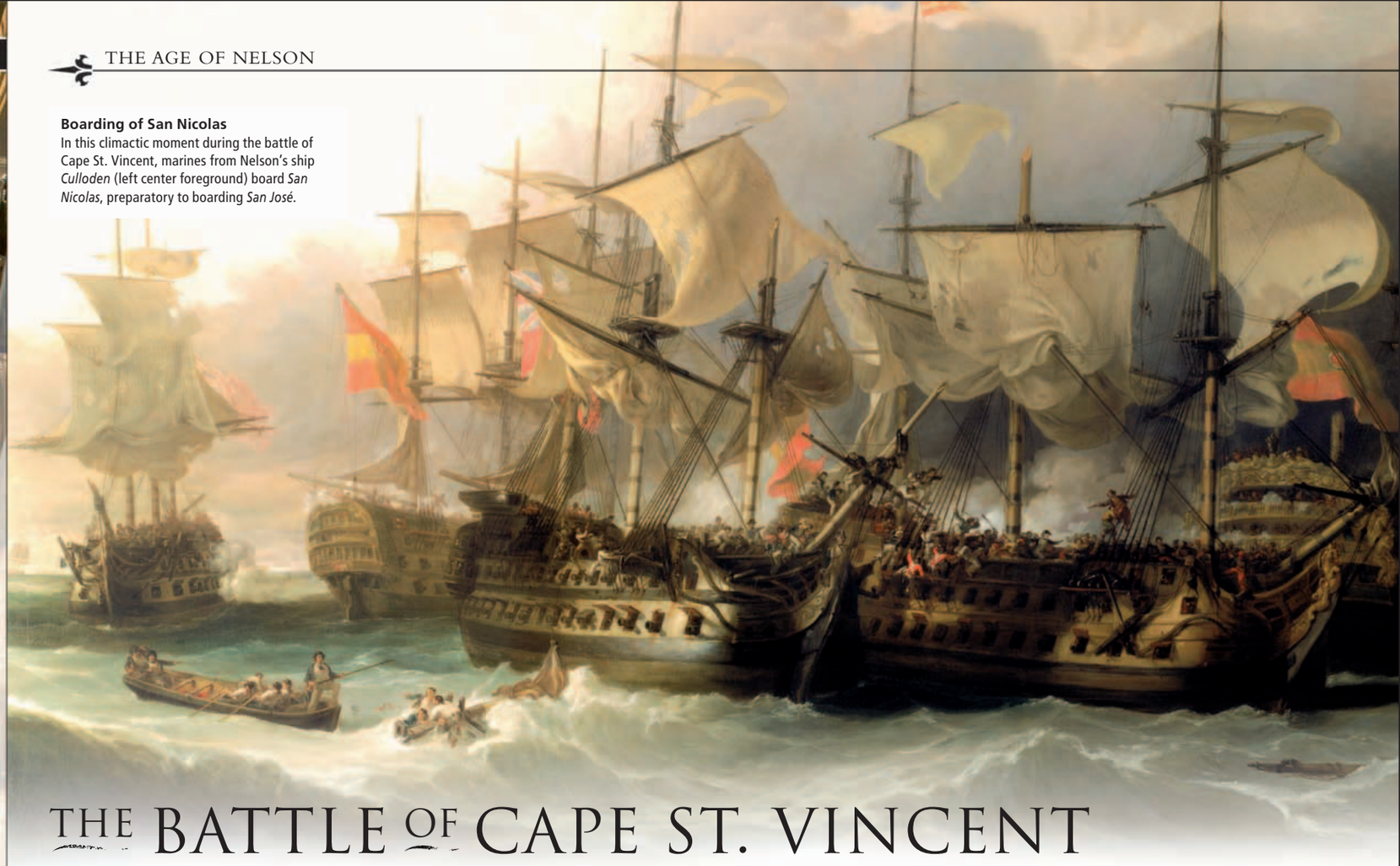
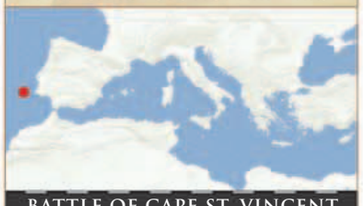


Boarding of San Nicolas
In this climactic moment during the battle of Cape St. Vincent, marines from Nelson's ship *Culloden* (left center foreground) board *San Nicolas*, preparatory to boarding *San José*.

THE BATTLE OF CAPE ST. VINCENT

In early 1797 the Spanish fleet sailed from its Mediterranean harbor at Cartagena, aiming to join the French fleet in Brest. This would create a combined naval force powerful enough to cover a French invasion of Ireland. British admiral Sir John Jervis was stationed off Cape St. Vincent to intercept the Spanish on their way north to France. Spanish admiral Don José de Córdoba intended to pause at Cadiz, but as he left the Mediterranean an easterly gale blew his fleet out into the Atlantic. When the wind permitted he turned back toward Cadiz on a course that brought him into sight of the British fleet early on the misty morning of February 14.

FRENCH REVOLUTIONARY WARS



BATTLE OF CAPE ST. VINCENT

Date	February 14, 1797
Location	Off the Algarve, southern Portugal
Result	British victory

COMBATANTS

BRITAIN	SPAIN

COMMANDERS

Sir John Jervis	Don José de Córdoba

FORCES

Ships: 15 ships of the line	**Ships:** 27 ships of the line

LOSSES

Men: 300 casualties **Ships:** none	**Men:** c.1,000 casualties **Ships:** 4 ships captured

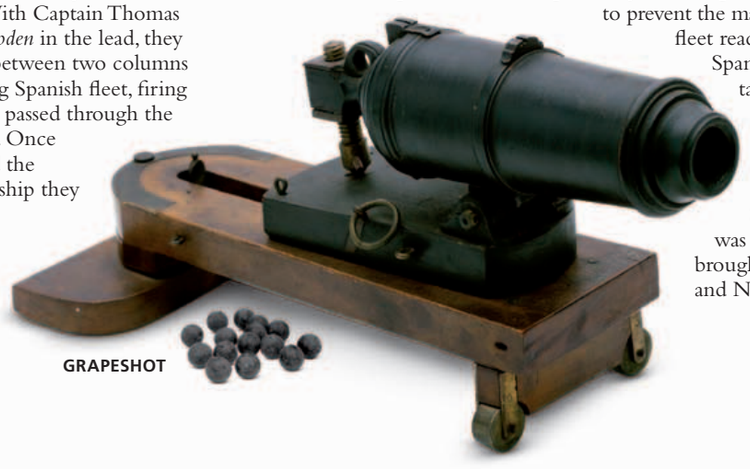
THE DIE IS CAST

Jervis had 15 ships of the line, and when the count of Spanish ships sighted rose to 27 he reportedly said: "Enough of that; the die is cast and if there are 50 sail I will go through them." The Spanish, despite their large numerical advantage, had no desire to fight. Their ships were large but their crews included few experienced sailors. Jervis had ensured that his men were superbly trained and led by able captains keen for action. The British ships formed a line ahead and astern of Jervis's flagship *Victory*. With Captain Thomas Troubridge's *Culloden* in the lead, they sailed into a gap between two columns of the approaching Spanish fleet, firing broadsides as they passed through the enemy formation. Once they were beyond the rearmost Spanish ship they tacked around in succession to pursue de Córdoba's fleet still keeping course for Cadiz. This maneuver was complicated by the intervention of ships from the Spanish column to leeward, which briefly attempted to break through the British line to join their colleagues to windward.

THE PATENT BRIDGE

Commodore Horatio Nelson had only joined Jervis's fleet the night before the battle, transferring from a frigate to Captain Ralph Miller's 74-gun *Captain*. He was near the rear of the British line. As his turn approached to tack in succession he instead ordered Miller to wear ship, reversing direction out of the line. This was contrary to orders, but a justifiable intiative, since Nelson could see that the Spanish were threatening to reassemble their split force and escape to Cadiz. *Captain* boldly engaged the center of the Spanish windward column, which included the 130-gun *Santisima Trinidad*, fighting alone until joined first by *Culloden* and then by Captain Cuthbert Collingwood's *Excellent*. At the climax of the battle the Spanish first-rate *San José* and the second-rate *San Nicolas*, both with shattered masts and corpse-strewn decks, became inextricably entangled. Although *Captain* was by this time uncontrollable, with its foretopmast over the side and wheel shot away, the ship's marines (and Nelson himself) boarded first *San Nicolas* and from there took *San José*—the dramatic double-boarding becoming known as "Nelson's patent bridge for boarding first rates." The slaughter ended with the ceremonious surrender of swords by Spanish officers.

Jervis's ships were in no fit shape to prevent the main part of the Spanish fleet reaching Cadiz. But four Spanish ships had been taken by a numerically inferior enemy and France's hopes of combining its naval forces with those of Spain were dashed. It was a fine victory that brought Jervis an earldom and Nelson a knighthood.



Carronade
The carronade was a short smoothbore cannon used by the Royal Navy from the 1770s to the 1860s.